

Phrasal verbs

NEW VERBS ARE FORMED BY ADDING AN ADVERB OR A PREPOSITION TO AN EXISTING VERB.

A phrasal verb is a compound of a verb and an adverb, a verb and a preposition, or a verb, an adverb, and a preposition. Phrasal verbs work like regular verbs, but they are mostly used in informal speech.

SEE ALSO

◀ 38–39 Verbs

◀ 40–41 Adverbs

Prepositions 60–61 ▶

Hyphens 106–107 ▶

Adverb phrasal verbs

Composed of an existing verb followed by an adverb, an adverb phrasal verb works in the same way as a regular verb—as a single unit. The adverb is essential to the phrasal verb's meaning, either intensifying the sense of the preceding verb or changing its meaning entirely. Adverbs like *up*, *down*, *out*, or *off* are often used to form phrasal verbs.

The adverb *up* changes the meaning of the verb *get*, resulting in a phrasal verb that means “to rise, usually after sleeping,” rather than “to receive or obtain.”

I got up early.

adverb phrasal verb

Most new verbs in the **English** language are **phrasal verbs**.



- The small words used to form phrasal verbs—**adverbs** and **prepositions**—are often known as **particles**.
- Phrasal verbs are **never** hyphenated.

I got up early because Daniel
We ran into Paulo, who was

Prepositional phrasal verbs

Prepositional phrasal verbs consist of a verb followed by a preposition, such as *by*, *after*, *in*, *on*, or *for*. The preposition links the verb to the noun or pronoun that follows—the direct object. Prepositional phrasal verbs are always transitive, but unlike adverb phrasal verbs, prepositional phrasal verbs cannot usually be separated by the direct object (see “Word order”).

stand by talk about
call on listen to
take after
wait for
run into

Versatile verbs

Only a handful of adverbs and prepositions are needed to create a range of phrasal verbs with different meanings. Using a different phrasal verb can completely change the meaning of a sentence. For example, “Paulo is looking after the game” means that he is in charge of the game.